

Factors leading to the Decline of Buddhism

The decline of Buddhism can be attributed to a complex interplay of various historical, social, and cultural factors that varied across different regions and time periods. Here are some of the key factors that have been identified as contributing to the decline of Buddhism in certain areas:

Ideological Decline:

Buddhism was founded on egalitarian ideals opposed to Brahmanical supremacy and Vedic rituals. However, similar problems of hierarchy, corruption and complex rituals emerged in institutional Buddhism over time.

For instance, the accumulation of wealth and power within monasteries undermined Buddhism's essence. Monks' involvement in worldly matters contradicted Buddhist principles.

Multiple divisions into sects and subsects led to a loss of Buddhism's original philosophical core. These structural and ideological issues resembled problems in Hinduism, eroding Buddhism's separate religious identity.

Hinduism's Reform and Assimilation:

On the other hand, Hinduism reformed itself by adopting Buddhist practices like vegetarianism and opposing animal sacrifice.

Hindu leaders like Adi Shankaracharya established (mathas) monasteries on the Buddhist model to revive Hinduism while critiquing Buddhist philosophy.

Fundamental philosophical similarities between Buddhism and Hinduism on concepts like karma, dharma and moksha enabled Buddhism's gradual assimilation into Hinduism from 500 CE onwards.

Buddha emerging as an avatar of Vishnu in Hindu texts facilitated the assimilation.

Lower castes found Buddhist egalitarianism attractive, causing the acceleration of the assimilation.

Loss of Royal Patronage:

Decline of major Buddhism-following dynasties like the Kushanas and the shifting of royal patronage towards Brahmanical Hinduism under the Guptas accelerated the decline of Buddhism.

This lack of state support led to the decay of Buddhist sanghas and monasteries.

Lack of Vernacular Literature:

Unlike early Buddhist scriptures composed in Pali, later were written in Sanskrit, meaning their ideas did not penetrate the vernacular-speaking masses in inland India.

This restricted Buddhism's expansion beyond urban elite groups.

Foreign Invasions:

Invasions from the north-west by non-Buddhists like the Huns and Turks (Khilji) led to vandalism and persecution of Buddhist monks and devotees.

These assaults disrupted Buddhist monasteries, pilgrimage sites and institutions like Nalanda.

The destruction of the Mahayana Buddhist sites in northern India by Islamic invaders from 1100 CE sealed Buddhism's demise in the land of its birth. Despite this decline, Buddhism's impact

remains evident through its profound influence on Asia's cultural and spiritual landscape....
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